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Towards Clarifying Shared Ancestry Between Munda and Old Indo-Aryan: A Selective Overview of Michael Witzel’s 1999 Paper

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Abstract

In this paper, we present a view of clarifying shared ancestry between Munda of Eastern India and Old Indo-Aryan languages. The prevalent view of Prof. Michael Witzel [1] is taken as the study case. The conclusion is that there are several spots in the prevalent arguments which make them less than water-tight and more work is necessary.

1 Introduction

There have been ongoing debates in the scholarly world between proponents of an outside-in view of the Indo-Aryans and an inside-in view. Authors like Prof. Michael Witzel form one side of the aisle. The debate also co-mingles with the decipherment efforts of the Indus Valley script with some camps supporting a Vedic language to go with the Indus valley civilization and others opposing such a view. In this paper, we do not directly address these questions, but examine a related question about ‘borrowing’ from other substrate languages into Vedic Sanskrit as even the core elements like verb inflections are suggested to have been borrowed [1].

In order to take a fresh approach, we explored the use of the artificial intelligence language model called ChatGPT¹. In a series of questions based on [1] we guided the model to the conclusion that Prof. Witzel’s arguments are not water-tight and more avenues of exploration exist, some suggested by the author himself.

This paper is structured as follows. In Section 2, we present the transcript of our discussion on March 28, 2023, edited for clarity. In Section 3, we conclude with a discussion of future work and a brief survey of other views.

¹ChatGPT Mar 14 Version.

2 An Investigation into the Munda-Vedic Sanskrit Relation

2.1 Summary of [1]

The paper discusses the potential influence of non-Indo-European substrate languages on the development of Old Indo-Aryan, including the Rigvedic, Middle, and Late Vedic periods. The author argues that the presence of substrate languages can be inferred from certain linguistic features found in the texts, such as loanwords and grammatical constructions.

2.2 Explication of Section 1 of [1]

The first section of Witzel's article, "Introduction: Indo-Aryan and substrate languages," provides an overview of the historical and linguistic context of the Indo-Aryan languages, as well as the concept of substrate languages.

The author notes that the Indo-Aryan languages are part of the larger Indo-European language family, which includes other well-known language groups such as the Celtic, Germanic, Slavic, and Romance languages. The Indo-Aryan languages were spoken in the Indian subcontinent and are known primarily through texts, such as the Vedas, which date back to the second millennium BCE.

The article then introduces the concept of substrate languages, which refers to the languages that were spoken in a particular area *prior* to the arrival of a new language group. These pre-existing languages may have influenced the development of the new language through various linguistic processes, such as borrowing of vocabulary or grammatical structures.

Witzel argues that the presence of substrate languages is an important factor to consider when studying the development of the Indo-Aryan languages. He notes that previous scholarship has tended to downplay the potential influence of substrate languages on Indo-Aryan, but that contemporaneous research has highlighted the need to reassess this assumption.

Overall, the first section of the article sets the stage for Witzel's argument that substrate languages likely played a significant role in shaping the development of Old Indo-Aryan.

2.3 Evidence Presented in Support

Witzel presents several lines of evidence throughout the article to support his argument that substrate languages played a significant role in shaping the development of Old Indo-Aryan. Here are some examples:

1. The presence of non-Indo-European words in Old Indo-Aryan texts, particularly words related to flora and fauna. Witzel argues that these words are unlikely to have been borrowed from other Indo-European languages, and instead point to the influence of pre-existing non-Indo-European languages in the region.

2. The presence of grammatical structures and syntax that differ from other Indo-European languages, particularly in the earliest Vedic texts. Witzel argues that these features can be attributed to the influence of substrate languages that had different grammatical systems.
3. The presence of "Vedic-Sanskritisms," or features of Vedic Sanskrit that do not appear in later Sanskrit texts, but that are similar to features found in other Indo-European languages. Witzel argues that these features may have been added to Vedic Sanskrit at a later date, possibly due to contact with other Indo-European languages, and were not present in the substrate languages that influenced the earliest forms of Old Indo-Aryan.
4. The analysis of loanwords in other Indo-European languages that are likely borrowed from non-Indo-European languages spoken in the Indian sub-continent. Witzel argues that these loanwords point to the existence of pre-existing non-Indo-European languages in the region that had a significant influence on the development of Old Indo-Aryan.

2.4 Internal Innovations Versus Borrowing

Suppose there is a grammatical structure that differs from other Indo-European languages, one may not think it necessary that it comes from substrate languages, for it may just be inherent in the Old Indo-Aryan language itself. That is, it is important to note that there are many factors that could contribute to the development of unique grammatical features in a language, such as contact with other languages or internal linguistic innovations.

However, in the case of Old Indo-Aryan, Witzel argues that the differences in grammatical structures and syntax found in the earliest Vedic texts are unlikely to have arisen from internal linguistic innovations or contact with other Indo-European languages. Instead, he argues that these features point to the influence of substrate languages that had different grammatical systems.

For example, Witzel notes that the early Vedic texts exhibit a complex system of verbal inflection, with many different verb forms that express nuances of tense, aspect, and voice. This system is quite different from the simpler verb systems found in other Indo-European languages, such as Latin or Greek. Witzel argues that this complexity can be attributed to the influence of substrate languages that had more complex verbal inflection systems.

2.5 Examples of Substrate Languages

Witzel provides examples of substrate languages that may have influenced the development of the complex verbal inflection system found in early Vedic texts. For example, he suggests that the Munda languages, which are spoken in eastern India and are not part of the Indo-European language family, may have contributed to the development of complex verb inflection in Old Indo-Aryan.

Witzel notes that the Munda languages have a complex system of verb inflection with many different forms, which is similar in some respects to the system

found in early Vedic texts. He also points to the fact that some of the earliest Old Indo-Aryan texts, such as the Atharvaveda, contain many words and phrases that are likely borrowed from Munda languages.

Witzel also notes that other non-Indo-European languages spoken in the Indian subcontinent, such as the Dravidian languages and the Tibeto-Burman languages, also have complex verb inflection systems that may have influenced the development of Old Indo-Aryan.

2.6 Transformation of Verb Inflections from Munda to Old Indo-Aryan

In his article, Witzel does not provide a detailed analysis of how the complex verb inflection system of the Munda languages may have influenced the development of the Old Indo-Aryan verb system. However, he does point to some similarities between the two systems and suggests that the Old Indo-Aryan system may have been influenced by the Munda system.

For example, Witzel notes that both the Munda and Old Indo-Aryan systems have a large number of verb forms, which are used to express different aspects of tense, mood, and voice. He also notes that both systems have forms that are used to express perfective and imperfective aspect, which are not found in other Indo-European languages.

Witzel suggests that the similarities between the two systems may be due to substrate influence, but acknowledges that more research is needed to fully understand the relationship between the Munda and Old Indo-Aryan verb systems.

2.7 Common Ancestor as Source of Shared Features

Herein we examine the idea that if both the Munda and the Old Indo-Aryan systems have a large number of verb forms, that could be due to them coming from a common parent, distinct from other Indo-European languages. In fact, this is a possibility that has been suggested by some linguists.

Nonetheless, the similarities between the verb inflection systems of the Munda languages and Old Indo-Aryan, as well as the presence of Munda loanwords in some Old Indo-Aryan texts, suggest that there was at least some contact and possible influence between these language groups in the past.

It is worth noting that, if Munda and Old Indo-Aryan have a shared ancestor, then their relationship would be deeper than just superficial contact and influence. In this case, the similarities between their verb inflection systems could be due to the fact that they both inherited certain features from their common ancestor.

However, it is also possible that the similarities are due to mere contact and influence between the two language groups, even if they share a common ancestor. For example, it is possible that the two language groups were in contact at some point in the past and borrowed features from each other's verb

inflection systems, even if these features had originally developed independently in their shared ancestor.

To elaborate, it is possible that certain features of the verb inflection systems were present in the shared ancestor of the Munda and Old Indo-Aryan languages, but evolved differently in the two language groups over time. In this scenario, contact and influence between the two language groups could have resulted in the borrowing of certain features from each other's verb inflection systems, even though those features were originally present in their shared ancestor.

However, it is also possible that the verb inflection systems in the shared ancestor were simpler or different than those in either the Munda or Old Indo-Aryan languages, and that the more complex systems in those languages developed independently. In this scenario, contact and influence between the two language groups could have resulted in the borrowing of certain features from each other's verb inflection systems, even if those features were not present in the shared ancestor.

2.8 Shared Geography

Given that both the Munda and Old Indo-Aryan are South Asian languages, two possibilities are plausible: a shared ancestor followed by sub-regional diversification and independent development.

On the one hand, it is possible that the Munda and Old Indo-Aryan languages share a common ancestor that existed in South Asia and gave rise to both language groups. In this scenario, the similarities between their verb inflection systems could be due to inheritance from their shared ancestor. On the other hand, it is also possible that the Munda and Old Indo-Aryan languages developed independently of each other, and that their similarities in verb inflection are the result of convergent evolution or contact and influence between the two language groups.

3 Future Work and Conclusion

3.1 Future Work

Witzel's article provides several suggestions for further research into the origins of the Munda and Old Indo-Aryan verb inflection systems. For example, he suggests that future research could investigate the syntactic and semantic functions of the various verb forms in both language groups, and compare these functions across different dialects and time periods. This could help to shed light on the evolutionary pathways of the verb inflection systems in each language group.

Witzel also suggests that future research could focus on the comparative analysis of other features of the Munda and Old Indo-Aryan languages, such as their phonology, lexicon, and syntax. By comparing these features across different dialects and time periods, researchers could gain a better understanding of the historical and linguistic relationships between the two language groups.

3.2 Other Works On the Munda-Vedic Sanskrit Relation

Some works which espouse differences from [1] include:

1. In his book "Linguistic Archaeology of South Asia" (2004), Southworth ([2]) argues that Witzel's views are based on a flawed methodology and that the similarities between Munda and Vedic Sanskrit are not indicative of language contact.
2. In his book "The Roots of Hinduism: The Early Aryans and the Indus Civilization" (2015), Parpola [3] suggests that the similarities between Munda and Vedic Sanskrit are due to a common Indo-European ancestor and that there is no evidence of significant language contact between the two language families.

In conclusion, it is likely that several scenarios can be proposed to explain a given history of languages and their evolution and evidence-based ruling-out is our only yardstick.

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